Activity 1 — Mapping the Service Chain at a Singapore Bank Branch

Topic	1 — Understanding Customers & Customer Service
Mapping	LO1 · Understand internal vs external customers and how the service chain shapes experience.
Format	Case Study + Peer Sharing
Duration	25 minutes
Roles	Groups of 4–5. Each group maps the chain; one member presents.

The Scenario

OCBC-style retail branch, Tampines. Mdm Rohani, 68, comes in to reactivate a dormant savings account so her CPF payout can be credited. The queue ticket says 12 minutes; she waits 47. At the counter, the teller, Wei Ming, finds the reactivation needs a signature-verification form that Operations must approve. Operations is understaffed and quotes 3 working days. Wei Ming has no authority to expedite and no way to see the Operations queue. Mdm Rohani has already made two trips. She says loudly that she will move her account to another bank, and other customers in the queue are listening.

Behind the counter: the branch manager has a service-level dashboard showing counter wait times but not back-office turnaround. Operations measures forms processed per day, not customer trips avoided. The digital team launched an app-based reactivation two months ago that nobody told the branch about.

What You Will Produce

A service-chain map naming every internal and external customer, the broken link, and one fix per link.

Materials: Whiteboard / flip chart · Service chain worksheet.

Discussion Questions

1. Who are the EXTERNAL customers in this case, and who are the INTERNAL customers? List every one.
2. Draw the service chain from Mdm Rohani's need to the outcome she actually got. Where exactly did it break?
3. Wei Ming was polite and followed procedure, and the customer still left angry. Whose service failure is this?

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4. Operations measures 'forms processed per day'. What behaviour does that metric produce, and what does it miss?

5. The app-based reactivation existed but the branch did not know. What internal service failure does that reveal?

6. Name one change per link in the chain that would have prevented this outcome.

Step-by-Step

1. Form groups of 4–5. Read the case aloud once as a group so everyone shares the same facts.

2. On a flip chart, draw two columns: EXTERNAL CUSTOMERS and INTERNAL CUSTOMERS. List every person or team in the case under the right column. Mdm Rohani is external — but so are the customers in the queue who overheard.

3. Draw the service chain left to right as boxes: Mdm Rohani's need → queue system → Wei Ming (teller) → Operations → outcome. Add the branch manager and digital team as boxes that FEED the chain from above.

4. On each arrow between boxes, write what is supposed to flow (information, authority, approval). Then mark with a red X every arrow where that flow failed.

5. For each red X, write the internal customer whose need was not met. Example: the arrow from Operations to Wei Ming should carry 'queue visibility' — it carries nothing, so Wei Ming's need as an internal customer is unmet.

6. Answer discussion question 4 explicitly: write the behaviour 'forms processed per day' rewards, and write what it makes invisible.

7. Agree ONE fix per broken link. Write each fix as a specific action with an owner, not a slogan — 'give tellers read access to the Operations queue dashboard', not 'improve communication'.

8. Nominate a presenter. Present the map in 2 minutes: the chain, the breaks, and your fixes.

Debrief — What a Strong Answer Looks Like

- The frontline is where the failure BECOMES VISIBLE, not where it is caused. Wei Ming did nothing wrong — he was set up to fail by the links behind him.
- Internal customers here: Wei Ming is Operations' customer; the branch is the digital team's customer; Operations is the branch manager's customer. Every one of those relationships failed.
- 'Forms processed per day' optimises throughput, not resolution. It is blind to Mdm Rohani's THREE trips — the metric would look healthy while the customer churns.

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- The undisclosed app feature is a pure internal-communication failure. A capability the frontline does not know about does not exist.
- Expected fixes: give the teller visibility of the Operations queue; give SOMEONE authority to expedite; measure customer trips not forms; brief the branch on every new digital capability.
- Link back to Topic 1: excellent external service always begins with strong internal service. This case is the proof.

Check Your Work

Your map names at least 3 internal customers, marks at least 3 broken links, and each fix is a specific action with an owner.

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